more than a week of suspended supplies before US Ambassador to Pakistan Anne Patterson apologised for a September 30 NATO helicopter incursion that killed three Pakistani soldiers. A US Embassy statement clarified that a joint investigation showed that American pilots had mistaken the soldiers for Afghan insurgents they had been pursuing. Acrimony between hawks in Islamabad and Washington, where a new White House assessment sharply criticised Pakistan for being 'unwilling to take action against Al Qaeda and like-minded terrorists', had been growing for months. As an Obama administration official told *The Wall Street Journal* in October 2010, 'there are real challenges we have with Pakistan' (*The Daily Times*, 2010).

Despite apology even at that time, the US-Pakistan relationship seemed to be reaching the breaking point. Although the US was well aware that Pakistan remained a crucial link in the US strategy in Afghanistan, it was fed up with Pakistan's slackness to take effective action against the terrorists. In this fury, the US failed to remember that progress in Afghanistan would not be sustainable if it came at the cost of creating more enemies for Pakistan's weak and unpopular government in the border regions.

It seemed that US impatience stemmed not only from the ongoing tussles but also from its apprehensions about the future ominous scenario that could emerge due to lost state control. It had deep worries about various factors like corruption, mismanagement, population explosion, water and food scarcity that could give impetus to extremism and militancy in Pakistan in future. A study conducted by the Congressional Research Service for the US law makers warned that Pakistan's ecological problems would likely to get worse due to climate change. Pakistan faced critical risks to food security in the coming decades due to a number of reasons including water scarcity, population growth and mismanagement. 'The combination of these factors could contribute to Pakistan's decline as a fully functioning state, creating new, or expanding existing new, or expanding existing, largely ungoverned areas.' The US was worried that the growth of lawless areas of the type seen now in Pakistan's tribal north-west was 'not in the US' strategic interest, given the recent history of such areas being used by the Taliban, Al Qaeda and other terrorist groups. The report further warned of future disasters as climate change leads to a melting of Himalayan glaciers, the source of most of the water in the Indus River. However, Pakistan's environmental